

# Chicago Tribune



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## Officials: US arsenal ‘beyond critical’

Pair tie shortage of Patriot missiles in Europe to Iran war

By Emma Burrows  
and Ben Finley  
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The U.S. military is experiencing a “beyond critical” shortage of advanced missile interceptors in Europe largely driven by President Donald Trump’s war with Iran, a U.S. defense official in Europe and a NATO official told The Associ-

ated Press, raising concerns about vulnerabilities in NATO countries to a potential Russian attack. The U.S. defense official said the most concerning shortfall involves Patriot missile interceptors, which can shoot down Russia’s high-speed ballistic missiles. The NATO official confirmed the low inventories of Patriots among American and NATO forces in Europe. Both spoke on condition of anonymity.

In the event of a Russian ballistic missile assault on, for example, a military headquarters or power plant, NATO could be in a similar position to Patriot-starved Ukraine and be forced “to take punch after punch in the mouth,” the U.S. defense official said. In Europe, the American military “definitely” does not have enough Patriots to stop any possible sustained ballistic missile attack and

would have “very limited” capability to defend against a single ballistic missile strike or a stray Russian missile that goes off course, the U.S. official said. It illustrates the cascading fallout from Trump’s decision to launch a war against Iran, a conflict that reaches the six-month mark Friday. U.S. missile stocks in Europe have been moved to the Middle East, where U.S. and Gulf allies have fired off significant numbers of interceptors, including Patriots, to thwart Iran’s drones and missiles.

Some of those attacks have killed and wounded U.S. troops. Though a Russian ballistic missile attack against NATO countries is not expected, CIA Director John Ratcliffe went to Moscow this week to warn Russia not to attack, The Wall Street Journal reported. Asked by reporters Thursday whether Ratcliffe delivered that message to Russian President Vladimir Putin, Trump offered a round-about response.

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## Kiss video devolves into political soap opera

Footage at center of Lyons Township FOIA fight could affect multiple races

By Dan Petrella and A.D. Quig  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

What started out with a kiss between two Democratic officials in a local township office has devolved into a southwest suburban political soap opera with the potential to reshape competitive races for Congress and the Cook County Board. The vehicle for that reckoning is, of all things, a Freedom of Information Act request — the bureaucratic tool the public can use to obtain police reports and zoning records — now being deployed by a Republican politician trying to obtain surveillance video proving her Democratic opponent engaged in a kiss that the Democrat acknowledges occurred, though not in a romantic way. The ensuing fight has resulted in dueling accusations, a canceled emergency meeting and a scramble over the video footage, which was shared with the Tribune late Thursday. Even by the standards of Lyons Township, where a corruption investigation that ensnared several local officials served as a side story to the federal probe that ultimately brought down former Illinois House Speaker Michael Madigan, the current conflict among local officials is rife with accusations and head-spinning subplots. At the center of the controversy is security camera footage from the office of Lyons Township Clerk Elyse Hoffenberg that captures a kiss between her and Bridgeview Mayor Steve Landek, the longtime township Democratic Party boss and a former state senator. Hoffen-

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## RACING TO FIND NEW HOMES

Hawthorne backstretch workers have to find new places to live and a new way of living before Monday deadline

By Robert McCoppin | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Eric Gutierrez grew up on Hawthorne Race Course’s backstretch, where horses and track workers lived. He and his family crammed into a 12-by-18-foot room with a concrete floor, no bedrooms and no kitchen. His mom cooked on a propane camping stove. At least they had a bathroom, unlike some of their neighbors, who had to share a common bathroom.

The family lived above the stables, where Eric’s father and mother took care of the horses day and night, feeding, watering and cleaning up after them. When Eric stepped out onto the balcony of their dorm in west suburban Stickney, he could smell the straw from the stalls below, but he could see the skyline of Chicago in the distance, and dream of bigger things. After graduating near the top of his class at Morton East High School, Eric was

admitted last year into Dartmouth College, where he is now an Ivy League sophomore doing medical research. But this summer, his family’s way of life was upended. As Hawthorne went bankrupt and closed, Eric’s family was among more than 500 residents living on the backstretch who had to find a new place to live and a new way of living. “It’s been my life, so you get to see a chapter close

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**Top:** Eric Gutierrez stands on Tuesday in the doorway of his family’s old apartment where he grew up above the horse stables at Hawthorne Race Course in Stickney.  
**EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

**Above:** The starting gate is placed to the side of the track after the last race of the day at Hawthorne Race Course on July 19. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

### INSIDE



**STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE**

## NIU interim coach builds for long term

Rob Harley, who enters his first season as Northern Illinois’ coach with an interim tag, is operating with a mindset that he’s building for the long term. **Sports**

## More problems arise for Bally’s Chicago

A former contractor claims he is owed millions for work on the \$1.7 billion casino complex going up in River West. **Business**

## Chicago man who got cyclospora sues Taylor Farms

The librarian alleges he contracted parasite from Taco Bell chalupa

By Rebecca Johnson  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A Chicago librarian who allegedly contracted a diarrhea-causing parasitic illness after eating a chalupa from a Portage Park Taco Bell has filed a

lawsuit against the company that supplied the lettuce, his attorneys announced Thursday. Alonso Zaragoza and his wife, Jadhira Sanchez, filed a federal lawsuit against Taylor Farms California and Taylor Fresh Foods Inc. last week. The Chicago couple accused the companies of growing, processing and distributing shredded iceberg lettuce that contained cyclospora. Zaragoza was the only one who got sick.

It’s believed to be the first lawsuit filed in Illinois related to this year’s unusually large outbreak, according to one of the couple’s attorneys, William Marler. “I look at lawsuits as consumers standing up for themselves,” Marler told the Tribune. “If consumers don’t stand up and make companies accountable for what they’ve done, there’s no incentive on companies to change

their behavior.” The deadly multistate outbreak, linked to iceberg lettuce, has raged on this summer. There have been over 10,000 cases reported nationwide of cyclosporiasis, including 1,535 confirmed and probable cases in Illinois, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention and the Illinois Department of Public Health.

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